Chamberlain. ‘His beard reaches down to his waist, and it is naturally white, but to make himself look younger he dyes it black. He goes about in a sort of tonjon [litter] carried by twelve men, and attended by horsemen, running footmen, elephants, horses and a hundred sepoys.’

Shuja put a good face on the privations of the march, but was as anxious as everyone else about the lack of planning and the growing problems with Baluchi marauders and dying baggage camels. He was also worried by the slow response from his future subjects to his letters entreating them to rally to his standard. Ever since Macnaghten had informed him of the plan to reinstate him, Shuja had been engaged in an energetic correspondence with the different tribal leaders of his old dominions, inviting them ‘in accordance with their family traditions to come forward and offer allegiance, and have their ancient rights and lands confirmed in perpetuity’. But the response had been a deafening silence, except from some of the Ghilzai and the Khyber chiefs, who had replied asking him to send money.[31]

There was also an ominous silence from the leader whose territory the army was now heading into – Mehrab Khan of Qalat. In the past the Khan of Qalat had been a fairly loyal follower of Shuja and had given him shelter after he fled from his defeat in Kandahar five years earlier. But he strongly disapproved of Shuja returning to power as the puppet of the British. When Burnes was sent to try and win him over – and to try and procure 10,000 sheep for the troops who had now been put on half-rations – Mehrab Khan was frank in declaring that he regarded the policy as tactless, ill planned and strategically wrong-headed. ‘The Khan, with a good deal of earnestness, enlarged upon the undertaking the British had embarked in, and declared it to be one of vast magnitude and difficult accomplishment,’ reported Burnes.

> He said that instead of relying on the Afghan nation, our Government had cast them aside, and inundated the country with foreign troops; and that if it was our end to establish ourselves in Afghanistan, and give Shah Shuja the nominal sovereignty of Kabul and Kandahar, we were pursuing an erroneous course; that all the Afghans were discontented with the Shah, and all Mahometans alarmed and excited at what was passing; that we might find ourselves awkwardly situated if we did not point out to Shah Shuja his errors; and that the Chief of Kabul (Dost Mohammad) was a man of ability and resource, and though we could easily replace him by Shah Shuja even in our present mode of procedure, we could never win over the Afghan nation.[32]

It was wise advice. As Burnes prepared to return to his army, having failed to procure any of the supplies he needed, or even the most tenuous support